

the *target audiences* see a particular message as fitting the same category as do the coders for the study. Finally, will the results for the 1996 presidential campaign hold up for other presidential campaigns? If this is, indeed, a *theory* of presidential campaign discourse, this issue must at least be approached.

Benoit, Blaney, and Pier have written a book that is a valuable read for the target audiences identified in the introductory paragraph to this review. The book is a well-presented case study with extensive data collected regarding political campaign discourse in the 1996 presidential campaign. While falling short of supporting the theory proposed by the authors, the work raises intriguing questions that suggest value to further study.

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Larson Consulting. *Smart Tournament Administrator* Version 02-05-01. Freeware.

In the mid-1980's, Dr. Gary Larson set out to debunk the notion that the process of matching preliminary debate rounds was "more art than science." Larson recalls anecdotally that many people scoffed at his insistence that a computer could match and tabulate debate rounds as reliably as the most experienced tournament administrators. Today, however, virtually every intercollegiate debate tournament, including the CEDA, NDT, and NPDA national tournaments, uses computerized matching and tabulation. A project that is now over 15 years old, Larson's Smart Tournament Administrator (STA) is an excellent software package for the full range of debate tournament data management chores. This review focuses on the most recent version (v2-05-01) which has successfully operated under the Windows95, Windows 98, Windows ME, Windows NT, and Windows 2000 environments.

STA is available as freeware, and can be downloaded from <ftp://ftp.wheaton.edu/pub/debate>. Downloads are available in both single install (single install.exe) and multiple floppy disk install versions.¹ The latter involves downloading both

¹ File Transfer Protocol requires right clicking on the file name, choosing "Save file to" and selecting a destination drive.

a self-executing installation program (multi-install.exe) and three supplemental files (disk1.bnd, disk2.bnd, and disk3.bnd), and requires three floppy disks. STA is updated on a fairly regular basis, and self-installing updates can be downloaded from the same site.

Operation documentation is available in a standalone Word document file (instruct.doc) that can be downloaded from the ftp site. This documentation adequately explains the basic functions and most of the advanced features of the software. However, several undocumented features are active in the latest version of the software. For example, when you display the Rank Order of Teams for a division, <F6> will open a dialogue box where you can enter the number of teams advancing to the elimination rounds. This prints an alphabetical list of the top “X” number of teams for posting purposes. Additionally, once the results of an elimination round have been tabulated, <F7> will print out team codes and competitor names of the non-advancing team. If you have an 800x600 display monitor (common on laptops), the default font setting produces a window image too large for your screen. Simply click the icon on the left-side of the title bar, choose configure, and check the “Use Angloss Screen Fonts” box. Any of the available font settings should fit your display.

If you are expecting glossy documentation and a professional looking graphic user interface, you will be disappointed by STA. Larson is not a full-time computer programmer, and the interface reflects the fact that his programming time is devoted to function rather than form. While it is clear that the software is not written in Visual Basic (therefore lacking many of the “pretty” features of most Windows-based interfaces), the software operates with an elegance that more than makes up for its bare-bones appearance.

The user interface is straightforward and relatively easy to understand. File initialization, data entry (schools, teams, judges, and rooms), strike/constraint information management, tournament pairing routines, and ballot tabulation all appear on the left-side of the main menu. The various display functions and back-up routines appear on the right-side of the main menu. Routines are selected in the familiar point-and-click fashion, and operated through a combination of data entry screens and function key commands (e.g. <F5> prints the current screen, <F10> or <Esc> exits the current screen).

Perhaps the most salient feature of STA is the speed of data entry, both for setup and tournament operation. Each data entry function has been designed to keep keystrokes to an absolute minimum.

The procedures for entering school, team, judge, and rooms data are elegant and efficient. The team entry routine prompts you for the school name, followed by the name of each debater, the division into which the team is to be entered, and a final confirmation that the team is active. Once a school has been entered, typing the first letter or two of that school's name auto-completes the name, allowing you to simply hit return rather than finishing typing. For maximum entry efficiency, enter debaters last name first since the program automatically generates standard alpha team codes using the first letter of each debater's name. Once entered, any of this information can be revised by pointing, clicking, and retyping.

Judge entry is similar. STA prompts you for the affiliation of a judge, the judge's name, number of rounds available, divisions for which the judge is ineligible, rounds the judge is unavailable, and confirmation of active status. The judge availability columns provide a high level of control regarding the judge assignment priorities. The values you enter in the committed (first priority), free (second priority) and hired (third priority) columns determine the number of rounds in which each judge appears in the judging pool, allowing you virtually to script judge usage.

Room entry is quick and easy. Enter the building/number in the first column, and the division for which the room is to be used in the round-by-round columns. STA then prompts you for the next room by auto-completing the building/number with the information from the previous entry. If the previous entry was Founders 101, to enter Founders 103 you need only backspace once to remove the numeral 1, replace it with the numeral 3, and you are ready to enter the usage data.

The program excels with respect to strikes/constraints/mutual preference entry. STA allows you to send an electronic list of judges to each school, and solicit each team's judge strikes, constraints and preference ratings. When schools respond to the message, their email replies can be entered effortlessly by merely selecting that option from the main menu. Of course, strikes, constraints, and judge preferences can be entered manually.

The true power of this software is experienced when matching and tabulating results. The pairing algorithms for preliminary rounds are flexible and powerful, allowing you to select a random, high-high, or high-low bracket matching routine on a round-by-round basis, and for judges to be assigned randomly, from the top, or from the middle of the bracket. The automatic pairing routine matches teams and assigns judges in a matter of seconds. The program also includes a manual matching mode. The elimination round pairing routine has a

different feel, prompting you for information unique to the elimination round environment. The screens for this routine are not complicated, but must be followed carefully.

Ballot entry may be STA's crowning achievement. In an attempt to minimize keystrokes, STA utilizes ballot codes to enter results. Rather than typing judge names (as other software packages require) you can access debates directly by entering the unique ballot code printed each ballot (ballot mode) or ballot label (label mode). The decision is recorded in a single keystroke (A for affirmative, N for negative), followed by the points for each debater and finally the rank for each debater (if ranks were selected in the setup menu). If the points assigned to a debater are between 20 and 29, there is no need to enter a leading 2, and half-points are entered merely by stroking the period. Ballot tabulation is best double-checked by blind entry – re-enter the data and the program will catch any discrepancy between the first and second entries, prompting you for necessary corrections. The elimination round results routine merely requires highlighting the winning team. Minority judges can be highlighted in the event of a split decision.

Judge substitution is equally efficient. To substitute a judge, simply select a pairing on the round display and highlight the judge to be replaced. Stroking <Enter> pops-up a list of replacement judges and their conflicts. Highlighting the replacement judge and stroking <Enter> completes the judge substitution.

Larson currently is working on two major improvements to STA. The first is printer performance. While he has reported a high level of success with a number of printers (namely Hewlett-Packard and Lexmark brand printers), other brand names (such as Canon) have produced less than optimal results. Additionally, Larson hopes to improve printer speed so large tournaments can take advantage of the ballot print mode which prints entire ballots, including participant names, rather than ballot labels. At the 2001 Sunset Cliffs Classic, Larson was able to print 20 long-form ballots per minute on an HP Inkjet printer, rivaling the time required to print ballot labels and stick them on pre-printed ballots. A second improvement due in the fall of 2001 is an improved mutual preference algorithm, focusing on the typical tendency to overuse highly preferred judges and underuse low preference judges.

While STA is a powerful and useful software package for debate tournament administration, it nevertheless has room for improvement. First, STA does not produce user-friendly elimination round result printouts. You can print the pairings for each elimination round, highlight winners and minority judges, and then paste these sheets

together. However, STA does not produce a single printout nor does it produce an elimination round bracket.

A second potential improvement deals with cumulation sheets. Currently, there is no option for displaying adjusted speaker point totals or speaker ranks. Most tournaments use the former for breaking team and speaker ties, and many tournaments still use ranks as an additional tie-breaker for individual speaker awards. While this information is available on the Rank Order of Teams display, it does not appear on the cumulation sheets. Including these two items would enhance the usefulness of the cumulation sheets considerably.

Finally, STA could better accommodate small tournaments. Because pairings are constrained by past meetings rather than potential meetings, the software has difficulty pairing small divisions, especially when multiple schools have multiple teams. Unless a tournament director is careful, small divisions might seem to be matching well through the early rounds of a tournament, but turn out to be locked in to violating normal matching constraints in the latter rounds. While it is certainly possible to use the manual pairing mode and a pre-set schematic to minimize this problem, STA could use a round-robin style matching option to ensure that all teams can have a maximum range of opponents.

While it is unlikely that any tournament software package can address every issue and satisfy the preferences of every tournament director, Smart Tournament Administrator remains a powerful tournament administration package. But perhaps the finest feature of STA is the programmer. Larson continues to adapt his software to the needs and preferences of the debate community. His selfless service to the debate community is at the heart of STA's success.

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Edwards, Rich. *Tab Room on the PC*. Version 04-04-2001. Freeware.

I should say from the outset that I consider Rich Edwards the closest thing that Baptists have to a Saint. He set the standard for tournament software pricing by offering his program for free when many gladly would have paid fistfuls for it. When I encountered a problem at 3:00 P.M. and Edwards suggested that I call him at 2:00 A.M. while he was on vacation, I

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